are a communal party. We are not like that. You may see that our party ideologue, Deen Dayalji, mooted the Antyodaya (welfare of the poorest) philosophy in 1967. And the Bhairon Singhji-led government in Rajasthan became the first to experiment with the philosophy. The secret of Modiji's successful rule in Gujarat was the implementation of policies right down to the most deprived tribal areas. I feel the first objective of the book is to rescue the BJP from the narrative that classifies working for the people or the welfare of the poor as left, right, capitalist etc. Secondly, while the left talks of class conflict, we focus on class coordination. So, on the one hand, we implemented welfare schemes for the poor, and on the other also implemented reforms for states. Now, we are seeing the results of those steps.

Q. The BJP is also accused of hypernationalism and polarisation?

Yadav: I don't believe there is any intolerance anywhere. Because there have been so many welfare schemes. In five years, I have never seen any news-item that said Ujjwala benefits were denied to someone because they belonged to a particular religion or that any village was denied power supply because it

"I want to rescue the BJP from the narrative that sees working for the poor as left, right or capitalist. While the left believes in class conflict, we focus on class coordination"

– BHUPENDER YADAV

was inhabited by people of a certain religion or caste. When we did not discriminate against anyone in our policies, why should there be any talk of favouritism or polarisation?

Q. Finally, what are the big lessons for the BJP in your book?

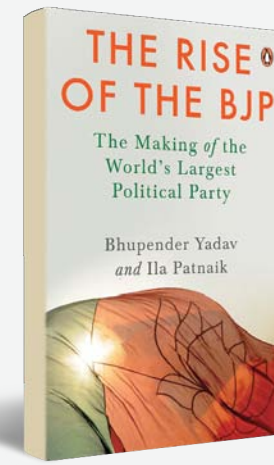
Yadav: One, that to stay in the driver's seat for a long time, national ambitions have to be balanced with regional aspirations. Two, leadership capacities should be developed at all levels because a block level leader is as important as an MP or MLA. Then, upholding the core principles of BJP's organisational strategy: eschewing dynastic succession, promoting internal democracy and taking collective decisions. Finally, monitoring the personal and collective moral principles of those who have been in power for long. ■

REVIEW

THE NEW POLITICAL MACHINE

Two books charting the BJP's journey to the top highlight how the saffron party has reshaped itself into a formidable political machine

BY RAHUL VERMA



▲ **THE RISE OF THE BJP**
The Making of the World's Largest Political Party
By Bhupender Yadav & Ila Patnaik
PENGUIN
₹699; 336 pages

The ascendance of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to the national centrestage in 2014 has provoked some serious scholarly attention in the past few years. Several books have been published presenting both sympathetic and deeply critical accounts of the party and its 'ideological mentor', the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), as well as biographical descriptions of several top leaders of both organisations. There are also new monographs focusing on how the rise of the BJP under Prime Minister Narendra Modi is reshaping India's political culture and its democracy.

It is in this context that the two books under review—one co-authored by senior BJP leader Bhupender Yadav and economist Ila Patnaik, *The Rise of the BJP: The Making of the World's Largest Political Party*; and journalist and academic Nalin Mehta's *The New BJP: Modi and the Making of the World's Largest Political Party*—provide valuable insights into the inner workings of the party. However, both books shy away from taking a normative position on what the rise of the BJP means for Indian politics, or from making an attempt to build a more general theory of how political parties expand their presence.

Yadav and Patnaik provide an account of the BJP's history from the Jan Sangh days to the 2019 campaign. This 300-page book is divided into 12 chapters and provides